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PRESS RELEASE

ENTRIES NOW OPEN FOR THE 2026 NATIONAL PRESIDENTIAL MSME AND CO-OPERATIVES AWARDS

The Department of Small Business Development (DSBD), together with the Small Enterprise Development and Finance Agency (SEDFA), has officially opened entries for the 2026 Presidential MSME and Co-operatives Awards.

The Awards recognise and celebrate South Africa's top-performing micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs), co-operatives and ecosystem partners whose innovation, resilience and enterprise development efforts are driving economic growth, job creation and inclusive development across the country.

The 2026 National Presidential MSME and Co-operatives Awards will follow a three-phased competition process, ensuring broad participation and representation from across South Africa.

Phase 1: District Pitching Competition

The Awards process will commence with the District Pitching Competition, where eligible MSMEs and co-operatives will submit their entries through an open online application system.

- Entries will be accepted from MSMEs and co-operatives across all local municipalities within each district
- All applications will undergo an eligibility and compliance screening process.
- Successful entrants will be invited by their respective SEDFA district offices to participate in the District Pitching Competition.
- Following the pitching sessions, one winner per award category will be selected to represent the district at the Provincial Awards.

Phase 2: Provincial (Premier's) Awards

The Provincial Pitching Competition, known as the Premier's Awards, will bring together the district winners from across each province.

- The Premier's Awards will be hosted in all nine provinces.
- Only district winners will be eligible to participate.
- Following the provincial pitching competition, one winner in each award category will be selected to represent the province at the national awards.

Phase 3: National Presidential MSME and Co-operatives Awards

The winners of the Premier's Awards in each category will advance to the national Presidential MSME and Co-operatives Awards, where winners will be announced.

Ten award categories are open for entries, recognising excellence across priority sectors such as agriculture, digital technology and manufacturing, as well as enterprises owned by women, youth and persons with disabilities.

The overall winner of the 2026 National Presidential MSME and Co-operatives Awards stands a chance to receive R2 million and national recognition as one of South Africa's leading small enterprises. Each category is worth R1 million, and each category winner will receive R500 000.

Applications are open and will be closing on 14 August 2026.

Applications can be submitted via the official Awards website:
<https://www.msmeawards.org/>

/ E N D S

FOR MEDIA ENQUIRIES

SEDFA

Boy Ndala
Email: bndala@sedfa.org.za
Cell: 0833404603

DEPARTMENT OF SMALL BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT

Noko Manyelo
Email: nmanyelo@dsbd.gov.za
Cell: 071 265 8611
